

The Two-Row-Wampum Belt

Rhaea Bailey
41560038
Professor Michael Jackson
Law 353-001

Canada's nationhood began with the treaties that they signed with First Nations. As these treaties were in English, First Nations offered settlers their understanding of the agreement. The two-row-wampum belt was a tool for conveying the Haudenosaunee or "Iroquois" interpretation of the treaties that were concluded with them. The Iroquois are some of the first peoples to engage in the treaty process with outsiders as well as to contribute to the understanding of treaty terms. The specific contribution made by the Iroquois was through the two-row-wampum belt. The two-row-wampum belt is a depiction of the intended relationship it was designed to convey at the treaties it was presented at. This paper will briefly look at two of the treaties in which a two-row-wampum belt was presented, discuss the meaning of the wampum belt and state my experience in re-creating this particular wampum belt.

The *Treaty of Albany* was the first official alliance between a First Nation in North America and the British Crown. This treaty was specific to the Haudenosaunee who had an advantage over the settlers as they outnumbered them and were more powerful. The settlers decided that it would be a good idea to have an agreement made so that there would be no problems from the Iroquois. The written treaty stated the British's conditions as well as including the separate governance rights of the two parties. The Haudenosaunee provided the spirit of this alliance; it was in the form of the Gus-Wen-Qah or the two-row-wampum belt. This belt was used to signify the understanding that they took from the treaty. The belt that was presented at the *Treaty of Albany* was created from shells that were made into beads. The specific belt that was given to the British at

this time became known as the two-row-wampum because of how it looked. The pattern of this belt, and what it stands for was described as:

“The belt showed two parallel rows of purple wampum on a background of white wampum. The white wampum symbolized the purity of the agreement. The two purple rows denoted the spirit of the nations’ ancestors and the separate, but parallel paths which they would each take in their respective vessels. One vessel, a birch-bark canoe, was for the Iroquois people, their laws, customs and way of life; the other, a ship, was for the British, their laws customs, and way of life. Three beads of wampum-symbolizing peace, friendship, and respect-separated the two row. The three beads were the link between the nations, but just as their paths never cross on the wampum belt, neither was to attempt to steer the other’s vessel.”¹

The two-row-wampum belt was of great significance in the *Treaty of Albany* as well as when the Royal Proclamation came into effect right after the treaty at Niagara in 1764. The treaty at Niagara was entered into in the summer of 1764 and was looked upon as the “most widely representative gathering of American Indians ever assembled.”² After the terms of this agreement were presented gifts along with a two-row-wampum belt were exchanged to represent the Aboriginal perspective on the terms of the treaty. Again, this belt was presented as it represents an understanding of peace, friendship, and respect where each nation can remain sovereign uninterrupted by the other.

However, the Royal Proclamation was interpreted without factoring in the Treaty of Niagara and the important Aboriginal understanding of that treaty. Instead, the Royal Proclamation has been interpreted to exercise sovereignty over First Nations. This claim was asserted even though the man who presented the treaty and its terms, Sir William Johnson, stated that “ these people had subscribed to a treaty with me at Niagara in August last, but by the present treaty I find, they make expressions of subjection, which

¹ Borrows, J., & Rotman L., *Aboriginal Legal Issues: Cases, Materials & Commentary 3rd Edition* at page 15

² Burrows, J., *Wampum at Niagara: The Royal Proclamation, Canadian Legal History and Self Government in Aboriginal Legal Issues: Cases, Materials & Commentary 3rd Edition* at page 26

either have arisen from the ignorance of the interpreter, or from some mistake; for I am well convinced, they never mean or intend anything like it... ”³

The two-row-wampum belt was critical to the way that these First Nations interpreted the proclamation and its concepts have to be interpreted with regard to the meaning of the belt. When the proclamation is read in conjunction with the two-row-wampum belt it brings the meaning of various concepts stated in the proclamation into a new light. These are concepts that discuss self –determination, in which the two-row-wampum and its conveyance of such concepts have not been included.⁴

In learning to weave this wampum belt I experienced various emotions. Just researching what a two-row-wampum belt symbolized made me have such a reverence for my creation. The belt stands for a relationship that was to be built on mutual respect and understanding. It stands for peace and friendship, but most importantly, it stands for the recognition of sovereignty. Each row of beads contributes to this understanding and with each bead I wove I tried to remember this.

The wampum belt was a big project, as I wanted to make it as authentic as possible. By authentic I mean, as close to the way that someone from the Iroquois Nation would have woven it. In creating the loom I chose a branch that had a curve in it so that it looked like a bow. I took two separate pieces of wood and cut fourteen notches into them

³ Burrows, J., *Wampum at Niagara: The Royal Proclamation, Canadian Legal History and Self Government in Aboriginal Legal Issues: Cases, Materials & Commentary 3rd Edition* at page 27.

⁴ Burrows, J., *Wampum at Niagara: The Royal Proclamation, Canadian Legal History and Self Government in Aboriginal Legal Issues: Cases, Materials & Commentary 3rd Edition* at page 27.

for the fourteen pieces of hemp that I would place inside in order to create the loom. I chose hemp, as it is the most natural fiber available, as I could not obtain sinew. Once the fourteen pieces of hemp were in place I began to string thirteen beads onto the loom and weave them. This process was very time consuming, but as it came to an end it was worth it for the journey of creating it alone. I have never been able to connect to a project so intimately as this one because it has allowed me to join in the creation of a legal translation of a First Nation's cultural perspective something that does not fit into the typical western notion of education, especially in a legal education. It is with great respect that I completed this project and had an opportunity to experience something different.

References

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